

## BISHER IN FLORIDA

# Star of Wonder, Star of Might, Star of Bronx

By FURMAN BISHER

Atlanta Journal Sports Editor

FORT LAUDERDALE, Fla. — All those years John McGraw carried on a crusade to uncover a Jewish player who would excite the ethnic taste buds of his Bronx clientele. Like a march from the synagogue they moved through the Giant clubhouse at the old Polo Grounds.



BISHER

Harry "The Horse" Danning, the catcher who almost had it. Phil "Big Swing" Weintraub, to whom major-league pitching was like a mystery novel. Andy Cohen, the little second baseman who had everything — charm, personality, crowd appeal, but no game. And the pitcher named Jake whose last name wasn't Jewish enough, so he changed it to Levy and got Mr. McGraw's attention. Cunning enough, but not pitcher enough.

The Yankees, just over the Harlem River Bridge, had a first baseman whose birth name was Whitner, but whose father was named Levy. This aroused even the haughty Yankees, who were reluctant to stoop to such box office trickery. But Whitner became Levy, though never the Yankee first baseman, except for a few games. He couldn't hit gentle pitching, and so he went back to the minors and became Whitner again.

All the time, the greatest Jewish first baseman of all ages was being raised not many blocks away, but in that dense forest Mr. McGraw somehow missed the tree. The boy signed with Detroit, and while Mr. McGraw slashed his arteries and cursed his fate, played himself into The Hall of Fame, where his presence now resides. The world knows him as Henry Greenberg.

And so the search went out. Stein. Goldsmith. Eisenstat. Rosenfeld. Rosenthal. Kislosky. Anybody whose name would look good on a shop window around 165th Street got a chance. But McGraw retired and died, and the great star never arose in the east to lead his flock.

## —'Boomer' Blomberg

Five years ago, when the New York Yankees had slumped into the humiliation and mire of 10th place, their one reward came in the free-agent draft. They drew the long straw.

It so happened that their luck in the administrative chambers exceeded that on the field, for their first turn at draft coincided with the year that a powerful young Israelite named Ronald Mark Blomberg came up as the choice morsel. Blomberg came from a family in Northeast Atlanta whose source of income is a wholesale variety store on Alabama street. They attend the synagogue, observe all the Jewish holidays and insisted that their son marry a Jewish girl.

And so today as the husband of Mara Goldsmith Blomberg, Ronald Mark Blomberg is about to deliver unto the Bronx his first major Jewish star of baseball. Already he has been endowed with a term of borough endearment, "The Boomer." He is the mark of the season for columnists and feature writers who look up the Yankees as they carry out their duties of the spring.

He finds this to his liking, for he is an openfaced child of 23, accessible, conversant and proud to be the Jewish star who landed decades after relentless search by McGraw had ceased, even though he came to rest a few degrees east of the location old "Muggsy" had in mind. This also is to his liking. Blomberg always wanted to be a Yankee, otherwise, he might have accepted some of those college scholarships that tempted him upon graduation from Druid Hills High School.

But, no academician he. "I did all right on my entrance exams, but when the chance to sign with the team I wanted to play for came, I thought I should go," he said.

## —If It Must Be, Let It Be

Four years Blomberg was in preparation for his emergence, moving up properly in the progression of the Yankee farm system from Johnson City, Tenn., to Kinston, N.C., to Manchester, N.H., and Syracuse, N.Y., until at last, last summer it was concluded he was ready.

"It might have worked out earlier if it hadn't been for military duty," he said. "I've had that one weekend every month, then I'd go away for two-weeks summer camp. Every year I'm hitting .300 when I leave, then I come back and I'm 0-for-30."

Apparently nothing got in his way last summer. He was 325 at Syracuse when the Yankees decided his time was due, and even a league of Vida Blues, Mickey Loliches, Dave McNallys and Jim Palmers failed to deter him from his course. He broke in with a double and a home run on June 24, and by October his average was .322.

Manager Ralph Houk had a habit of benching him for left-handed pitching. "I hit it in the International League," Ron protested mildly.

"That's why those left-handers are in the International League," Houk said.

Now Blomberg is resigned to it. Besides, he has other business matters at hand. He played 57 games in the outfield last year. This year they tossed him a first baseman's mitt, and that's his station, presumably to be shared with Danny Cater, a veteran who bats right-handed. And at no small risk to Houk's peace of mind.

"You should have seen the mail I got from the Jewish people."

See FURMAN BISHER, Page 4-D